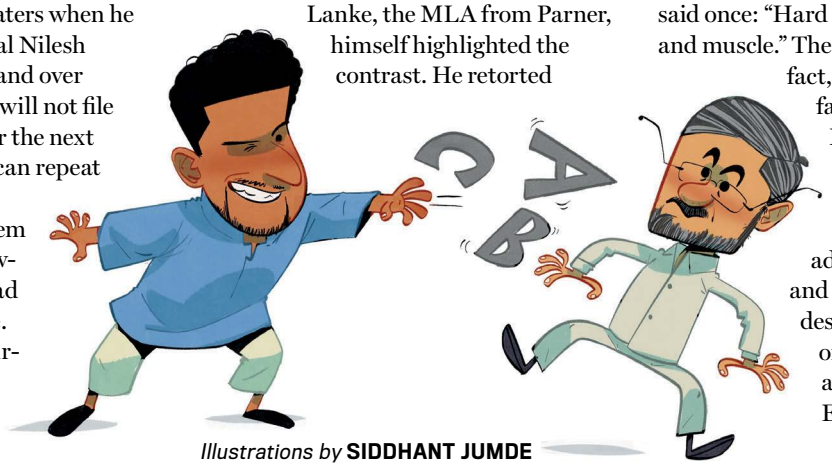
▶ MAHARASHTRA

AAMCHI ENGLISH

You'd think its history of language politics would have nixed such a possibility. But politics never ceases to surprise. There's a hot new item in Maharashtra's campaign polemics: English proficiency, as a marker of education. With a deficiency in the former allegedly implying the lack of the other! Dr Sujay Vikhe Patil, BJP MP from Ahmednagar, took Maratha politics to these unfamiliar waters when he took a swipe at his rival Nilesh Lanke's lack of command over English and Hindi. "I will not file my nomination if, over the next month, my opponent can repeat my speeches verbatim even after learning them by rote," he said, throwing a dare to the Sharad Pawar NCP candidate. Vikhe Patil, a neurosurgeon, speaks with all the nerve of the well-heeled—his dad, state revenue minister Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, is a cooperatives and education baron.

Lanke, the MLA from Parner, himself highlighted the contrast. He retorted that he grew up in a rural agrarian family, a good country mile away from English-medium education. And that was no hurdle when it came to public service, said the graduate from Yashwantrao Chavan Maharashtra Open University. He could speak in Parliament in Marathi, he said, but put out a post on X in English to taunt his tormenter right back, echoing something his political master had said once: "Hard work beats money and muscle." The Maratha agitation, in fact, was a key formative factor in the creation of Maharashtra and the state has had CMs like Vasantdada Patil, known for his administrative acumen and grasp over statecraft despite being educated only up to Standard V and with no functional English or Hindi. ■



Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

LUCKY PRASADA



Jitin Prasada was a second-generation loyal campwallah to Congress bigwigs, but fortune started smiling on him only after he decided to venerate other gods. Presently ensconced in the Yogi cabinet, he now looks set to pole-vault back to the national stage as the BJP candidate from Pilibhit. That's a step up for the former Rahul Gandhi acolyte, given that he replaces another high-profile Gandhi scion, Varun. The first *prasada* he got after jumping ship to the BJP was the plum PWD department. With the saffron momentum carrying him, his flight to the Lok Sabha may not see too much turbulence. Word on the street is that he may now get a call-up to the Union cabinet if the BJP forms government again. ■

▶ THE CUTBACKS

RISE & FALL

On other points, the phrase 'Modi ki guarantee' may be open to debate, but it sure doesn't cover one thing: a ticket to ride to the Lok Sabha. Even if you've proved your street cred as an ace broncobuster. Eleven of 2019's Top 20, who won with the highest margin of votes, don't have a ticket to this edition of India's political IPL: 10 are from the ruling BJP. Diya Kumari, ranked No. 11 last time from Rajsamand, is the only one who has risen in life: to deputy CM, Rajasthan. Sanjay Bhatia (Karnal, Haryana) and Ramakant Bhargava (Vidisha, MP) can at least tell folks back home they had to make way for ex-CMs M.L. Khattar and Shivraj Singh Chouhan.



2. SANJAY BHATIA (BJP) • *Karnal, Haryana,* ***Winning margin*** **656,142**



4. SUBHASH CHANDRA BAHERIA (BJP) • *Bhilwara, Rajasthan,* ***Winning margin*** **612,000**



5. RANJANBEN DHANANJAY BHATT (BJP) • *Vadodara, Gujarat,* ***Winning margin*** **589,177**



6. PARVESH VARMA (BJP) • *West Delhi, Delhi,* ***Winning margin*** **578,486**



10. UDAY P. SINGH (BJP) • *Hoshangabad, Madhya Pradesh,* ***Winning margin*** **553,682**